been taken away by the Intelligence Agency (Al Jazeera 2017). These activists included 'prominent poet Salman Haider, bloggers Waqas Goraya, Aasim Saeed, and Ahmad Raza Naseer, and social rights activist Samar Abbas' (HRW 2017). These activists had been 'vocal critics of militant Islamist groups and Pakistan's military establishment'. After their disappearance 'the government immediately blocked access to their websites and blogs' (HRW 2017). In an interview with the BBC, one of the bloggers, Aasim Saeed, talked about his involvement with a 'Facebook page' that was 'critical of Pakistan's military establishment, called Mochi, "because since the inception of Pakistan they've always been ruling us directly or indirectly"' (BBC News 2017d). According to Saeed, he was questioned about Mochi, especially 'why he was critical of the army' and his connection to the Indian Intelligence Agency, the RAW. Saeed claims that he was tortured during his incarceration. Waqas Goraya in another interview with the BBC also claimed he was picked up by '"a government institution" with links to the military' because 'he ran a satirical Facebook page critical of the influence of the Pakistani military in the country's political system' and was tortured (BBC News 2017c). Salman Haider's article in BBC Urdu also highlights the torture and questioning about his blog, in particular his 'sympathy' for the Baloch plight. While the bloggers were eventually returned after protests by civil rights activists, their disappearance was further complicated, where their lives were put at risk, when a 'counter-campaign' against them that was 'backed by a number of TV anchors' accused them of blasphemy (BBC News 2017c). Ironically, the campaign against the bloggers included online pages that could have fallen under hate speech, but 'despite reports to both the PTA and the FIA, no action was taken against the people operating the accounts and pages running such campaigns, nor were measures taken to block the sites themselves, thereby putting the activists' reputations and lives at risk' (Aziz 2018). The case of the bloggers in particular highlights the extent to which online activism is being silenced in Pakistan by the security establishment. Most of the bloggers who spoke out eventually fled the country seeking asylum elsewhere. The refusal of the state to crack down on hate speech against the bloggers further highlights the indiscriminate application of PECA 2016, which has become yet another tool of surveillance in an increasingly securitized Pakistan.

In the case of the blasphemy laws, the government of the PML(N) ironically through its crackdown on social media and the internet the PML(N) government further 'weaponised' the blasphemy laws (Inayat 2017). Instead of addressing the draconian nature of blasphemy laws in Pakistan, Nawaz Sharif in March